

// No man is an island //

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What fun in playing solo

A quick guide to the world of multiplayer mayhem

Kawabonka launcher
GameSpy 3D
Find it on Mindware



Let's face it. As game technology currently stands, artificial intelligence (AI) is an oxymoron. Small wonder then, that avid gamers are forced to seek greater challenges in the online world. Once you've mastered the single-player experience, the only option left is to test your mettle against human opponents.

However, there is a catch—playing resource-hungry games online requires a fast connection (read broadband). Let's glance at the most critical factors that affect any network connection—ping, latency, and bandwidth. Ping (often confused with latency) is the amount of time it takes for a packet of data to travel to the server and back to your computer. Lower the ping time, faster the connection. Latency is defined as the response time, that is, the time it takes between you giving a command (pressing the trigger) and its execution (firing the gun). It's possible to have high latencies even with very low pings (if the server is overloaded with intensive applications). Finally, higher the bandwidth, faster the connection. However, if you try and connect to a server overloaded with network traffic, you'll still get very low pings.

So where does that leave us poor souls in India? Broadband is still a distant gleam on the horizon. The only course of action is to hunt for local servers where the lag (the time between giving a command and seeing it executed) won't be crippling, or use the LAN provided by the cablewalla to host multiplayer sessions.

Indian Communities

As far as the gaming scene in India is concerned, the only Internet server we have is at www.kawabonka.com. This lone server satisfies the needs of our *desi* hardcore gamers. Kawabonka runs *Quake III Arena* and *Counter Strike* servers on a regular basis. Relatively obscure games such as *Unreal Tournament 2003* or *Battlefield 1942* are set up on demand. The main hurdle in hosting more games is their complete lack of availability and gamers' reluctance to buy legal copies of games. As Ricky Kapur, who manages the Kawabonka server, says, "The problem is mainly that enough users don't own legal copies of the games, usually required to play online. Therefore, setting up a server is quite pointless if only four to five people have a legal copy of a game! Add to this the fact that a lot of games don't arrive at all in India!" Bleak, indeed.

Since Kawabonka has a very limited online presence, it's up to the local cybercafes to encourage multiplayer gaming and hopefully make gamers move on to Internet gameplay. Two notable examples are Skirmish in Mumbai, and Surf's Up in Pune. These cybercafes hold tournaments on a regular basis and are breeding grounds for multiplayer talent in India.

The popularity of team-based games such as *Counter-Strike* has led to the formation of groups or 'clans', as they're called in gaming parlance. Clan members always stick together and take part as a team in all games that allow it. Although meeting in real-life is pretty hard to do because of the geographical